work through a mobile phone and PDA. She uses her mobile device to scan city maps and find the best shopping spots. She transfers money from her ICICI account in Mumbai to Telstra (a mobile service provider) for paying her mobile phone bills, sends SMS to find out about flight timings, and keeps her life organised with her PDA organiser. There are many such people in the global workforce today.

The pressure that has accumulated for developing applications towards these hardware platforms is tremendous. This, in turn, means developing software applications which squeeze the maximum power out of mobile devices. Consider the example of mobile phones. The GSM system is now used in 171 countries, while the number of GPRS networks in commercial deployment exceeds 55 worldwide. A similar growth is expected in the PDA market.

There are numerous forums and initiatives by mobile and wireless device manufacturers informing interested developers about applications for the mobile platform. These are the best places for beginners or budding developers to ask questions about development of mobile computing applications and the standards that govern them.

Possibilities

The scope of applications that one could develop for the mobile platform is exhaustive. Most people think 'mobile phone' when they think of mobile devices, but devices like PDAs and pagers also fall into the mobile category. Applications could be classified into categories such as business, games, entertainment, communications, music, graphics, navigation, educational, and so on.

Simple applications such as Short Messaging Services (SMS), stock tickers, and weather status to complex applications such as banking and financial transaction services can be developed for the mobile platform. You could either develop a standalone software for the device or develop something which requires the connectivity of devices through some standard of communication. By standalone software we mean applications such as organizers, enhancers, cosmetic improvement software, better input techniques, etc. All other mentioned applications or services fall into the range which need a wireless communication means for messages to be relayed amongst devices.

What other applications can be developed for mobile platforms? Here's a list: Database software, document readers, PowerPoint presentations, keyless entry for security devices, SMS and logo utilities for cellular phones, movie players, city maps, fax applications to use the handheld device as a fax machine…. And there are plenty of other applications which could be creatively unleashed or which could come out later when the need arises. A cutting-edge application like banking or financial transaction services might require more labour and expertise, whereas an individual could look into options like enhancers, organizers and word processors for PDAs, and ringer tone applications, icons, games and other simple interface applications for mobile phones. Applications like wireless access to intranets and database administration through Palms and mobiles can be developed only after acquiring considerable expertise in the area of development.

Mobile application development has been put into use to change people's lifestyle. Once an idea makes business sense, either the individual sells the idea to a company or builds his/her own team and makes the product

Lavina Poorswani

eVectorMobile

Learning and help

The first step in forging a career in the mobile industry is finding out about training and coaching available for mobile applications development. No single coaching class or training institute offers a truly comprehensive course for mobile application development in India. However, NIIT, Aptech, and a few other institutes do offer training on Java and in some areas of telecom and networking technologies.

Mobile enthusiasts should build on their existing skills through exhaustive reading and figure out where the possible bottlenecks might be. They must refer to the multitude of knowledge bases and pose questions to experts over the Internet. Ashish Gupta, CEO of Notcomguys.com, recommends self-learning rather than taking coaching from a novice institute.

As mentioned earlier, companies that know the potential the mobile market wields have started forums and communities to boost the developer community towards the mobile platform. Some of them would assist you in getting your product in the market too. Most hardware

Jargon Buster

GPRS: General Packet Radio Service, a radio technology for GSM networks that adds packet-switching protocols, shorter set-up time for ISP connections, and offers the possibility to charge by amount of data sent rather than connect time.

GSM: Global System for Mobile communications, the most widely used digital mobile phone system and the *de facto* wireless telephone standard in Europe. GSM is now one of the world's main 2G digital wireless standards.

i-mode: The proprietary packet-based information service for mobile phones. i-mode delivers information (such as mobile banking, and train timetable) to mobile phones and enables exchange of e-mail from handsets on the network. It is very popular in Japan, but is not currently being used elsewhere.

SyncML: Synchronization Markup Language is an industry-wide effort to create a single, common data synchronisation protocol optimised for wireless networks. SyncML's goal is to have networked data that supports synchronisation with any mobile device, and mobile devices that support synchronisation with any networked data. The SyncML consortium was set up by IBM, Nokia and Psion among others and is supported by Symbian.

WAP: Wireless Application Protocol is a set of communication protocol standards to make it easier to access online services from a mobile device. WAP can be used for accessing Internet type services on mobile phones or handheld devices.